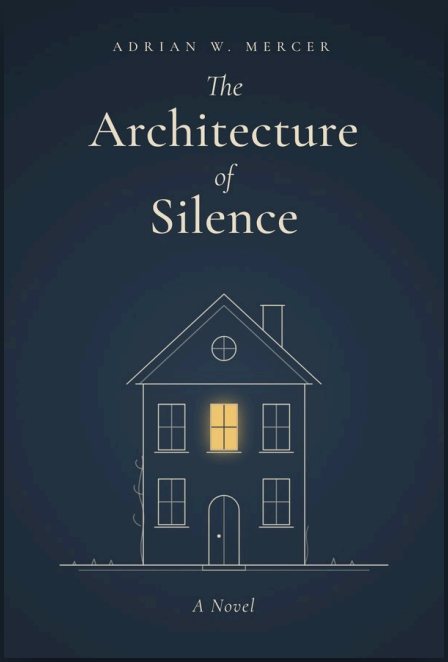


FREE CHAPTER

The Architecture of Silence

Chapter One · Adrian W. Mercer

CHAPTER ONE

Wren's End

The house at Wren's End had been waiting for sixty years, and it had not tidied up.

Eleanor found the table laid for four. Plates, cups turned down on their saucers, a butter dish with its lid on, all of it under a fur of dust so even and so soft it looked deliberate, as though someone had dressed the room for a photograph and then forgotten to take it. The clock on the mantel had stopped at ten to six. Outside, the garden had grown up to the sills and pressed its leaves against the glass, as if it, too, wanted to see what happened next.

She had been told the house was empty. It was not empty. It was full to the ceiling with the particular silence of rooms in which something has been left unsaid.

The solicitor had warned her on the telephone. "Your grandmother was very clear," he had said, in the voice of a man reading from a card. "Nothing was to be moved. Not by us, not by anyone. She paid the rates every year until she died, and she never once came back." He had paused, and Eleanor had heard the scratch of a pen. "I'm afraid

there is no inventory. I'm not sure anyone has been inside since the winter of 1953."

She had driven north with a box of bin bags, two pairs of rubber gloves, and the firm intention of being finished by Sunday. Eleanor was an archivist. She spent her working life deciding what to keep and what to let go, and she was good at it. She did not, as a rule, believe that houses had feelings.

Now she stood in the doorway of the dining room with the bin bags still folded in her hand and found she could not make herself step onto the rug.

Four places. Her grandmother, her grandfather, her mother, who would have been six that winter. And a fourth. A fourth plate, a fourth cup, a fourth chair pushed back a little from the table, as if whoever had been sitting there had stood up in a hurry.

Nobody in the family had ever mentioned a fourth.

She made herself go through the rest of the house the way she would go through an unsorted collection: methodically, touching nothing, noting everything. The kitchen, where a tea towel still hung over the rail of the range, stiff as card. The front room, where the curtains had faded in stripes where the sun came through the gaps. The stairs, which complained at every step. Upstairs, three bedrooms with the beds made, and a fourth door, at the end of the landing, that was locked.

She tried it twice. She told herself it was a linen cupboard.

It was getting dark by the time she came back down, and she realized she had not thought to check whether the electricity was connected. It was not. She found candles in a kitchen drawer, beside a ball of string and a book of ration coupons that had never been used, and she lit two of them on the dining table because it was the only surface in the house she could not bring herself to clear.

That was how she came to be sitting on the bottom stair, eating a sandwich from a petrol station and looking at the cupboard under the stairs, when she noticed that its little door was not quite shut.

Inside were the usual things. A broom with most of its bristles gone. A pair of Wellington boots, small, a child's. A coal scuttle. And behind the coal scuttle, pushed right to the back where the ceiling sloped down to meet the floor, a biscuit tin with a picture of a lighthouse on the lid.

It was heavier than it should have been.

She carried it to the table and set it down between two of the dusty plates, and for a long moment she simply looked at it, because she had worked in archives for eleven years and she knew the difference between a box that has been forgotten and a box that has been hidden.

The lid came away with a soft sigh of old air.

Letters. Dozens of them, then more than dozens, packed upright like files in a drawer. Every one in an envelope. Every envelope addressed in the same narrow, forward-leaning hand to Mrs. M. Hale, Wren's End. Every one stamped.

Not one of them had been posted.

Eleanor took out the first one and turned it over. On the back, in pencil, someone had written a number: 1. She took out the last one. 212.

Outside, the wind moved the garden against the windows. The candles leaned and straightened. Somewhere above her, in the room at the end of the landing, something settled with a small, wooden sound, the way old houses do when the temperature drops.

She told herself that was all it was.

Then she opened the first letter, and began to read.

Keep reading

The Architecture of Silence is available in paperback, ebook, and audiobook.

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